Two negotiations that continued after Independence under Patel's direct oversight were those pertaining to Junagarh and Hyderabad. Interestingly, both of them threw up the possibility of going to the UN, but Patel prevented it decisively. Because these events happened within India, we tend to think of them as politics rather than diplomacy. But as V.P. Menon has so ably chronicled, the exercise involved the toughest negotiations we can imagine. And whether it is in their objectives, strategy or tactics, they remain worthy of deep study even today.

That there were differences between Nehru and Patel on referring the invasion of Jammu & Kashmir to the UN is a well-known fact. Indeed, that was only one aspect of a larger divergence on handling the issue. This eventually saw Nehru divest Patel of the responsibility in the cabinet for Jammu & Kashmir and hand it over instead to Gopalaswami Ayyangar. On China, I have already examined how the two leaders reacted differently to its professed posture vis-à-vis India. But for all this, the discipline that the government, Parliament and politics impose ensured that much of the disagreement remained restricted to their internal correspondence. In response to Nehru's sensitivity to criticism on foreign policy, Patel gave him an assurance that he would limit the forum of expression to cabinet meetings.

Rather than focussing on what has been already highlighted, it may be worthwhile to explore some other views that are less known publicly. One relates to the difficult navigation of the Cold War era by Indian foreign policy. Significantly, on such issues, Patel was often the voice of moderation and caution. He felt that there was little to gain by excessively antagonizing Western powers, especially when India's direct interests were not at stake. The issue was not so much about specific choices and positions but more a discomfort with a larger attitude. From time to time, they found echo in positions that were also taken at that time by C. Rajagopalachari. As India–China ties worsened at the end of the 1950s, foreign policy views were asserted more independently by serving members of the Nehru cabinet. The point to appreciate is not whether they were right or wrong in their immediate stance. It is more that they came out of a stronger sense of national interest rather than an ephemeral sentiment of global solidarity.

There are two live issues right now in respect of Indian diplomacy on which Patel offered his views in his lifetime. One pertains to the US, and he obviously had a much less suspicious view than Nehru. In 1948, a year